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including anti-incumbency, has become a non-issue as the battle of the Thackerays became the issue. The Sena has never had it so bad. The party's tally has fallen from 69 in 1999 to 44 seats this year and it has performed worse than its ally BJP, which has won 46 seats. The reason for the rout of the Sena and a major reason for the victory of the Congress-NCP combine is Raj. His party is trailing second in 12 seats apart from the 13 seats it won. The saffron combine has paid heavily and the ruling front has harvested the rebellion of Raj. As BJP leader Vinod Tawde points out: "Of the 96 seats in Mumbai, Thane and Nashik, Raj's party has

caused damage in 48 seats."

Having decimated the Shiv Sena to its lowest in 15 years the MNS, not surprisingly, is seen as the new emerging opposition in the state. Happy with his performance in the elections, Raj says, "That 13 candidates of the MNS have won proves that the Marathi *manoos* has shown faith in the party." The fact that cousin Uddhav (Shiv Sena working president) was not visible after the defeat has only aggravated the generation of rumours. But this is not the end of the Thackeray rivalry. Having got the legitimacy he was seeking, it's only a matter of time before Raj systematically starts deconstructing

MAHARASHTRA

Total Seats 288

PARTIES		SEATS 2009	SEATS 2004	SEATS 1999	SEATS 1995
	Indian National Congress	82	69	75	80
	Nationalist Congress Party	62	71	58	*
	Shiv Sena	44	62	69	73
	Bharatiya Janata Party	46	54	56	65
	Maharashtra Navnirman Sena	13	*	*	*
Independents and others		41	32	30	70

* Parties didn't exist